



Judge Q&A: prepared answers

AaaS · Accessibility as a Service · Team SUBARNAREKHA · Pratikshya Padhi, OAV Jamdhar · Odiapreneur 3.0

Presenter prep. Keep answers to 15–30 seconds; the **bold line** is the point to land. If you don't know, say so: “I don't know yet; here is how we'd find out.”

WHY THIS, WHY ODISHA

Q1 Why Odisha first? Hindi has more speakers.

Three reasons. Odia is badly served by global tools, so that is where the real gap is. Odisha has an active digital-service mandate in 5T and Mo Sarkar. And this is our state, so this is where we can credibly land a pilot. **Odia-first is the hard problem; the engines already cover 22 Indian languages for what comes next.**

Q2 Doesn't Bhashini already do this?

Bhashini is the language-engine layer: translation and speech as APIs. AaaS is the accessibility product on top of it: guided voice form-filling, name transliteration, scanned notices read side by side, voice navigation without dead ends. **Bhashini gives India voices; AaaS gives Odisha's citizens hands, eyes and ears. We could plug Bhashini in as an engine tomorrow. If they ask “so you're just a UI?”: so is UPI: the rails existed, the product made a billion people use them.**

Q3 Why not Chrome's read-aloud, Google Translate and a screen reader?

An elderly Odia-speaking citizen will not combine three tools. None of them speak Odia numbers, read scanned circulars into Odia, or fill a form by voice, and most send data to the cloud. **We put those pieces together as one button, in Odia, running offline.**

Q4 Isn't this just an accessibility “overlay” like accessiBe?

Overlays claim a script makes a site “compliant” and are rightly criticised for it. **We claim nothing about the host site. We give the citizen a working way through it, and we are open source, self-hosted and auditable.**

WHAT WE BUILT

Q5 Did you build this yourself?

Answer truthfully, in your own words: what you designed and decided, what you wrote, and who helped (guide teacher, open-source models, any AI coding tools). Judges reward honesty. **Show ownership by knowing the architecture and the hard problems below cold. That proves understanding better than any claim.**

Q6 Which AI models do you run?

Four open-source engines, all on this laptop: **IndicWav2Vec** (AI4Bharat) for Odia speech-to-text, **IndicTrans2** (AI4Bharat) for translation, **MMS-TTS** (Meta) for Odia, Hindi and English voices, and **Tesseract** for OCR. Easy Read is our own rule engine. **No cloud APIs, no chatbot.**

Q7 Isn't it just a wrapper around existing models? What's hard?

The models are commodities; the product is everything between the citizen and the model. The Odia voice model is **silent on digits**, so we turn numbers into Odia words. The speech model writes English words **phonetically in Odia script**, so we match links by sound. Word-for-word translation turns the name Purnnachandra into **“full moon”**, so we transliterate names. The translator also **changed dates** on long notices (2026 came back as 2021), so we hide numbers from it and put them back afterwards. **None of that ships in any model.**

Q8 Why rules for Easy Read, not an AI chatbot?

A government notice with an invented deadline is worse than no notice. Rules are predictable, auditable line by line, and run offline on an ordinary laptop. **They cannot make up facts.**

Q9 How accurate are the voice, translation and OCR?

Good on clear speech and printed notices; weaker on noisy rooms and poor scans. Handwriting does not work. That is why voice commands offer choices instead of guessing, forms ask again, and documents are shown **next to the original. An imperfect Odia reading beats an English page the citizen cannot use at all, and the original is always on screen.**

DEPLOYMENT, PRIVACY AND COST

Q10 What does a website have to change?

One line of code (a script tag). The widget is about 0.5 MB, has no dependencies, and is isolated so it cannot break the page. For sites that haven't adopted it, our Chrome extension adds the same button. **We ran it on the real jajpur.odisha.gov.in and ssepd.odisha.gov.in.**

Q11 Where does citizen data go? (DPDP Act 2023)

To the institution's own server, for example at OCAC, and nowhere else. Audio is processed in memory and discarded, and we keep no accounts and log no content: only usage counts per feature. **Data stays in Odisha.**

Q12 Does adding this make a website WCAG-compliant?

No, and we deliberately do not claim that. Real compliance means fixing the site. AaaS gives citizens a way through today while that work happens.

Q13 Will it scale? How fast is it?

Four stateless services behind one gateway, so scaling is standard server work. Repeated pages and sentences come from cache, including a translation cache that survives restarts. **Don't quote numbers: show it. First use takes seconds; repeats are instant.**

Q14 What if a model fails, or there is no internet?

Everything runs offline on the laptop. Each service has a backup mode, and the widget shows which engine answered. **It degrades honestly instead of dying.**

Q15 Who pays? How is it sustained?

The state, once, for every department: one deployment at OCAC serves every portal. It is open source (Apache-2.0), so there is no lock-in, any IT firm can run it, and other states adopt it free. **Like UPI: shared rails, adoption first; support and hosting sustain it.**

HONEST SCOPE

Q16 Does it do sign language?

Not yet, and we say so. A three.js concept exists in the repo, but a half-good avatar would hurt deaf users more than help. **We chose to perfect voice, reading and forms first.**

Q17 Which languages? What does adding one cost?

Odia, Hindi and English today. The engines support most scheduled Indian languages, so a new language is configuration plus native-speaker testing. **A new language, not a new product.**

Q18 What's next after the hackathon?

A pilot on one district portal (Jajpur) and one board site (BSE Odisha); a native-speaker review of the Odia wording; and Bhashini as an alternative engine. **Our ask: give us one site.**

Never say

- Models we don't run: Whisper, IndicConformer, Piper, NLLB, or any LLM / chatbot
- An exam module (cut) or a working sign-language avatar (concept only)
- That a site becomes "WCAG-compliant"
- Latency or accuracy numbers from memory: demonstrate instead
- "21 lakh disabled people in Odisha" (unverified). Use Census 2011: 2.68 crore disabled people in India